some six hundred years after Ashoka's death, his memory was alive and well and had wormed its way into places stretching from the hilly ranges of north-west India to the Gangetic plains in the east. The Chinese monk mentions Gandhara as the place where Ashoka's son had governed; Sankisa as the holy place where Ashoka was reported to have 'erected a stone pillar thirty cubits high, and on the top placed the figure of a lion'; Ramagrama as the stupa site whose relics the emperor unsuccessfully coveted; and Pataliputra as the city where he reigned.[29]

Faxian described practically every place in relation to legends around Ashoka. Some of these he would have known from the Chinese version of the *Ashokavadana*, others would have been recounted by local people. Sometimes there is a mixture of both. This is suggested by his description of a message that he believed was encoded in Ashoka's epigraph at Pataliputra. The inscription was on a stone pillar and, in the words of Faxian, recorded that 'King Asoka presented the whole of Jambudvipa to the priests of the four quarters, and redeemed it again with money, and this he did three times.'[30] This story, as the poignant end to Ashoka's life has highlighted, figures in the *Ashokavadana* and Faxian would have been familiar with it. However, there was no allusion in that text to these deeds of the emperor being engraved on a pillar. Possibly, this tale was told to him by the local folk at Pataliputra who, like him, would have seen the surface of a pillar ascribed to Ashoka as bearing an indecipherable inscribed message. Evidently, by this time, the Brahmi script in which the Ashokan epigraphs were written, was no longer understood, allowing the writing to be 'read' in ways which satisfied the beliefs and expectations of local antiquarians and pilgrim travellers.

Local folk memory around Ashokan relics seems in this instance to have been uncommonly long lived. Some two hundred years later, such evidence of Ashoka's long afterlife in popular memory centres on a story around the Pataliputra pillar told by that other famous Chinese pilgrim, Xuanzang, who